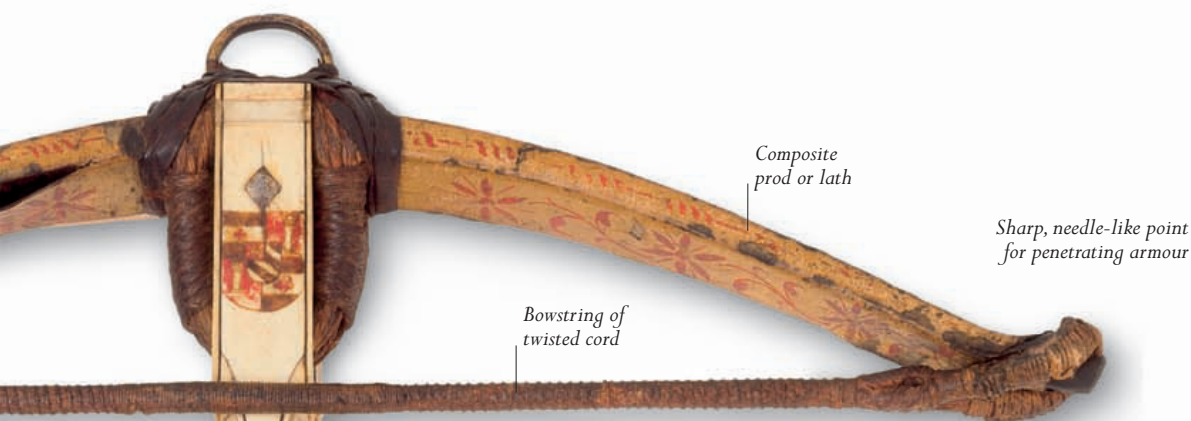




▲ CROSSBOW

Date c.1460

Origin Europe

Weight 4.4kg (9¾lb)

Length 72cm (28¼in)

Widely used in Europe from the 12th century, the crossbow, when fired from the shoulder, was very effective against armoured knights (see pp. 78–79). Although the bolt was released with great power, crossbows were slow to reload, so their rate of fire was far lower than longbows.

Groove for bolt

Revolving nut released by trigger below

Steel pin to engage mechanism for spanning bow

Broadhead bolt

◀ CROSSBOW BOLTS

Date c.1500

Origin Germany

Weight 35g (1¼oz)

Length 37cm (14½in)

Shorter and heavier than longbow arrows, bolts (or quarrels) had different tips depending on the effect required. Barbed broadhead bolts were used primarily for hunting, whereas chisel-headed arrowheads were used against armoured soldiers. The tip of the bolt served as a sight when aiming.

Sharp point and edges

Barb

► LONGBOW ARROWS

Date c.1520

Origin England

Weight 42g (1½oz)

Length 75cm (29½in)

Longbow arrows, also called “clothyard” arrows (named after the standard early 14th-century length of cloth), were mass-produced in medieval England to supply the king’s longbowmen. The fletching (feathers) stabilized the arrow in flight.

◀ BROADHEAD ARROWHEAD

Date c.1500

Origin Europe

Weight 28g (1oz)

Length 4.5cm (1¾in)

Broad iron arrowheads with barbs were able to inflict a deep, wide wound, and the barbs would cause terrible (often fatal) damage to the victim as they sliced through body tissue.

► LONGBOW

Date c.1540

Origin England

Weight 730g (25¾oz)

Length 2m (6½ft)

Originating in northern Europe during the “Migration Period” (c.400–800CE), the longbow came into general use only by the late 13th century. Drawn to the ear (rather than to the cheek), the superior tension of the bowstring gave increased range. A modern archer using a replica of this bow (recovered from the wreck of Henry VIII’s *Mary Rose*, which sank in 1545), shot an arrow to a distance of 328m (360 yards).

◀ BODKIN ARROWHEAD

Date 15th century

Origin Europe

Weight 7g (¼oz)

Length 12cm (4¾in)

With their sharp pointed ends, bodkin arrowheads could breach mail and were capable of penetrating weak points in plate armour. In battle an archer might stick such arrows in the ground in front of him for easy access.

Nock slots around bowstring

Shaft of ash or birch